view that appeared suddenly with Jinnah in the 1930s. It can be traced back centuries to the differences between the Emperors Akbar and Aurangzeb. In fact, the intellectual origins of Pakistan are derived from a sixteenth-century Islamic scholar from Punjab, Ahmad al-Sirhindi. A prominent member of the Naqshbandi Sufi order, Sirhindi loudly denounced Akbar's eclectic beliefs and his liberal attitude. In order to understand the subsequent history of Pakistan, therefore, it may be more instructive to read Sirhindi rather than Jinnah.

As the country hurtled towards independence in the mid-1940s, the demands of the Muslim League became increasingly strident. Amid growing tensions and frequent riots, the decision was taken to divide India along religious lines. The meeting that finalized Partition was held on 2 June 1947 in Viceroy Mountbatten's study, under a large oil painting of Robert Clive[1]. The Indian National Congress was represented by Jawaharlal Nehru, Sardar Patel and Acharya Kripalani. The Muslim League was represented by Jinnah, Liaquat Ali Khan and Rab Nishtar. In addition, there was Baldev Singh representing the Sikhs. Lord Ismay and Sir Eric Miéville, two of the Viceroy's key advisers, sat along the wall. The decision was announced at 7 p.m. on 3 June on All India Radio. The Viceroy spoke first, followed by Nehru and then by Jinnah. Pakistan was a reality.

No date had been announced for the handover. However, when Viceroy Mountbatten was later asked about it at a press conference, he replied that the final transfer of power to Indian hands would happen on 15 August—just seventy-two days later! It appears that this was a unilateral decision Mountbatten made—he had not consulted the Indian National Congress, the Muslim League or even Downing Street about it. It was a shock to everyone. It is unclear why Mountbatten opted for this date; it may have been no more than a sentimental attachment to the day on which the Japanese had surrendered to the Allies in 1945. It is instructive how the twists and turns of history can often be based on the most arbitrary of factors.

The partition of India was a major project. Writers Lapierre and Collins have aptly dubbed it 'the most complex divorce in history' and yet it had to